

Anatomical directions

Eight comparisons, one reference position. Write the best directional term for each sentence.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Word bank

Superior / inferior Anterior / posterior Medial / lateral
Proximal / distal Superficial / deep

Use anatomical position throughout: upright, facing forward, palms facing forward. Describe the person's own right and left.

- 01 The head is _____ to the chest.

- 02 The vertebral column is _____ to the sternum.

- 03 The nose is _____ to the ears.

- 04 The ears are _____ to the nose.

- 05 The elbow is _____ to the wrist.

- 06 The fingers are _____ to the elbow.

- 07 The skin is _____ to the underlying skeletal muscle.

- 08 The brain is _____ to the skull.

Make the answer stick. Cover the word bank and try the worksheet again. For each answer, point out the reference structure and explain the relationship in plain language.

Check your comparisons

- 01 **Superior.** The head lies above the chest.
- 02 **Posterior.** The vertebral column lies behind the sternum.
- 03 **Medial.** The nose is closer to the body's midline.
- 04 **Lateral.** The ears lie farther from the body's midline.
- 05 **Proximal.** The elbow is nearer the upper limb's attachment to the trunk.
- 06 **Distal.** The fingers lie farther along the limb from the trunk.
- 07 **Superficial.** Skin lies nearer the outside surface.
- 08 **Deep.** The brain lies farther beneath the body surface.

Two common mix-ups

Proximal vs. superior: Proximal follows a limb toward its attachment; superior means higher toward the head.

Superficial vs. anterior: Superficial means nearer the surface; anterior means toward the front.

References used to verify terminology

National Cancer Institute, SEER Training Modules: Anatomical Terminology.
training.seer.cancer.gov/anatomy/body/terminology.html

OpenStax, Anatomy and Physiology 2e, section 1.6: Anatomical Terminology.
openstax.org/books/anatomy-and-physiology-2e/pages/1-6-anatomical-terminology

Original wording, diagrams, and exercises. Reference material was checked on 3 October 2026.